

Headline Writing

District Meet • 2026



You are a copy editor for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

Write the headline assigned for each of the given **six** stories. Use the following system: all upper and lower case letters, spaces, punctuation marks and symbols count as 1. Capitalize the first letter of the first word of each headline. You may use either upstyle (capitalizing the first letter of every word) or downstyle (capitalizing the first letter of the first word and the first letter of proper nouns only thereafter). Remember that main headlines belong on the top line and secondary headlines belong under the main headline. You have **30 minutes**. Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Story 1 — Write: 1-line headline counting 22-28

The school will implement an educational artificial intelligence platform on all district devices starting next week. The platform, called LurnAI, will be integrated into school systems to provide students with safe and structured access to AI.

“LurnAI prioritizes human connections within its programming rather than immediately generating quick answers,” library media specialist Hafma Ali said. “We felt it was important to provide students with safe access to artificial intelligence where they can learn how to use AI responsibly.”

While the platform is available campus wide, using it is optional for teachers.

“I like that the school has full control over the prompts generated,” U.S. history teacher Charles Parkes said. “I can adjust parameters and even see what students are writing. It’s nice that we have the flexibility to use it or leave it alone.”

But Ali said it’s important to note that AI can still be prone to making mistakes.

“It may not be perfect,” she said. “It’s still a large language model, so we have to see it as a tool but also check carefully for any errors it may produce.”

Story 2 — Write: 2-line headline with each line counting 24-30

The district plans to purchase 100 new buses with state-of-the-art safety features in June. The new buses will be equipped with three-point seatbelts in each student seat, along with some other safety features.

“My job is to make sure students are getting to and from school safely,” Transportation Director Tom Branson said. “These buses are a huge step for us.”

In addition to seatbelts, the new buses will have updated driver airbags, high-intensity LED lighting, high-resolution front and rear cameras, lighted stop arms, school bus signs and strobe lights.

“It was time for us to replace our buses anyway,” Branson said. “We’re glad that this new set of updates come with these features.”

Freshman Tommy Barrow said he is ready for the change.

“I just think it’ll be good to have new buses because the one I ride every day is so old,” he said. “It smells weird and some of the seats have been ripped. It’ll be nice to have a more comfortable ride.”

Story 3 — Write: 3-line headline with each line counting 16-22

High school students can select a free outfit Saturday as the Leaguetown Parent Association hosts a formalwear clothing swap ahead of next month’s prom.

In addition to offering free clothes, the LPA will take donations for the swap in the front office of every secondary school campus in the district until Friday.

“Let’s face it,” LPA president Lynn Bohra said. “It’s expensive to get dressed for prom. If every student buys a brand new outfit for a formal dance every year, think of all the amazing and expensive dresses and suits that are never worn again. They’re just wasted, and that’s a shame.”

Bohra said her goal for the program is not only to reduce waste but also to help families save money.

“Styles change, and people grow every year,” junior Tabitha Kent said. “I like that our parent group is doing something to make a fashionable prom outfit more accessible for every student.”

Story 4 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 6-12 and 2-line secondary headline with each line counting 26-32

Repair work has begun on the science wing after a heat lamp started a small fire in the greenhouse last week. No students or staff were injured in the fire, but Principal Keith Johnson said smoke caused unseen damage to facilities.

“Everything in that hallway, including several classrooms and offices, became saturated with smoke,” he said. “We’ve got a lot of work ahead of us to complete the repairs.”

Science classrooms affected by the smoke will meet in the library or cafeteria while crews make repairs.

“It’s a small change of venue, but we’re still keeping up with the same material,” AP Chemistry teacher Margie Perez said. “You’ll be taking the same notes. We’ll even do some demonstrations. We’ll be ready for the AP test in May.”

In addition to cosmetic repairs to the walls and ceiling, the district installed air purifiers to mitigate the smell of smoke and dust.

“You can smell it in the whole building,” sophomore Daisy Mason said. “It gets a little better every day, but it’s going to be a while before we forget about this fire.”

Story 5 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 8-14 and a 1-line secondary headline counting 26-32

The Leopard bass fishing team won its first tournament at Lake Ray Roberts last weekend. The team, led by seniors Corey Morrison and Jake Tiffin, started competing for the first time this year.

“We’ve been wanting to do this for years,” Morrison said. “Over the summer, we finally got our team signed up for the right league and found a sponsor for the team. It’s been a long time coming.”

At the fishing tournaments, teams split into pairs and spend the day fishing from a boat — all catch and release. Winners are based on number of fish caught and total weight of fish caught.

“Our strategy is to get to 10 fish as soon as possible,” Tiffin said. “After that, we just hope their weight will get us close enough to the top. So there is a little bit of luck involved. Last weekend, luck was on our side.”

Morrison and Tiffin reached their 10-fish goal in the afternoon and came out on top thanks to one fish.

“Most of the fish we bring in are like 2 pounds,” Morrison said. “I caught one 6-pound fish this weekend, and that won us the tournament, I think. He was so fun to bring in.”

Story 6 — Write: 1-line headline counting 24-30

For the past five years, junior Henry Talbot has played the harp with his church music ensemble, practicing with the group of adults twice a week and performing every Sunday. Having never met another student who played his instrument, he was shocked when new student junior Violet Patmore announced to their third-period calculus class that she was a dedicated harpist as well.

Now, with Patmore’s help, he plans to start a club, hoping other harpists or other musicians who play unique instruments will join.

“My mom started teaching me to play when I was in the fifth grade,” Talbot said. “I’m not sure how good I am, but I always have a small solo at some point during each performance on Sundays at church. I think the audience likes the way it sounds.”

Talbot said he and Patmore have had two other harpists sign up to play with them once every two weeks.

“I’ve never met another student who played the harp, either,” Patmore said. “When Henry pulled me aside to tell me he played, too, I was shocked. I’ve seen a harp quartet play before, and it sounded amazing. I think that’s our ultimate goal — to get a small group together, start practicing, then maybe we can start playing small weddings and stuff. Maybe we can even make some money for college.”

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Headline Writing Entry Sheet

All letters (upper and lower case), numbers, punctuation marks, symbols and spaces count as one (1). Place one letter or other unit in the appropriate spaces below. Remember to leave spaces between words. Note that the number of lines you are given on this sheet corresponds to the number of lines required for each headline. Write your number on the upper right-hand corner of this sheet.

■ Headline Number 1

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 2

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 3

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 4

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

_____ *main headline*

_____ *secondary headline*

■ Headline Number 5

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

_____ *main headline*

_____ *secondary headline*

■ Headline Number 6

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

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Headline Writing Contest Tips and Samples

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judges.

1. Headline writing is different than the other contests. It is suggested you pace yourself. You have about five minutes for each headline. Don't watch the clock, but be aware of the time you are taking to complete a headline. It is better to have four or five good headlines rather than six mediocre ones.
2. When writing the headline, first highlight or underline all the important words in the story. Then write a sentence based on those highlighted words.
3. After you have your first sentence, go back and begin editing out words. If you have a multi-line headline, separate the lines at a recommended area. This means you should not split phrases or ideas. Make sure all types of phrases — noun, verb, adverbial, adjective and prepositional phrases especially — are on the same line. Continue eliminating words until you get to a point where the headline fits. It may be necessary to re-write the headline one or more times or to take a different approach before you get the key idea. Remember to eliminate all unnecessary words such as article adjectives (a, an, the). In many cases a comma (,) can substitute for the word "and."
4. You may use a printed thesaurus or dictionary without any notes or markings inside. You may write in upstyle or downstyle.
5. Make sure you are within the prescribed count. Under no circumstances should you be under or over the maximum count. Judges are instructed not to consider any headline under or over the prescribed count.
6. Write headlines using active verbs in either present, future or present perfect tense. Follow the style of the headline. If it is a fun story, write a fun headline. If it is a serious story, write a serious headline.
7. Do not sacrifice accuracy for creativity or cuteness.
8. Normally, the main headline is used to grab the reader's attention. It is not necessary, although it is possible, to have a verb in the main headline when you have a secondary headline. The secondary headline should do one of two things: emphasize the significant aspects of the story or emphasize the unusual.
9. AP Style provides guidelines for headline writing. It is not required for contestants to follow AP Style, but a consistent style is recommended. Students may use a printed AP Stylebook (with no notes or markings inside) in the contest.

The following are additional basic headline rules for you to follow:

- avoid starting the headline with a verb
- use single quotes
- avoid using the same word twice in a headline
- avoid unfamiliar abbreviations
- do not end the headline with a period or exclamation point

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School to implement AI tools 28

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★ STORY #3

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for prom outfits 16

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A Hot Mess 10
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after fire in science wing 26

★ STORY #5

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